

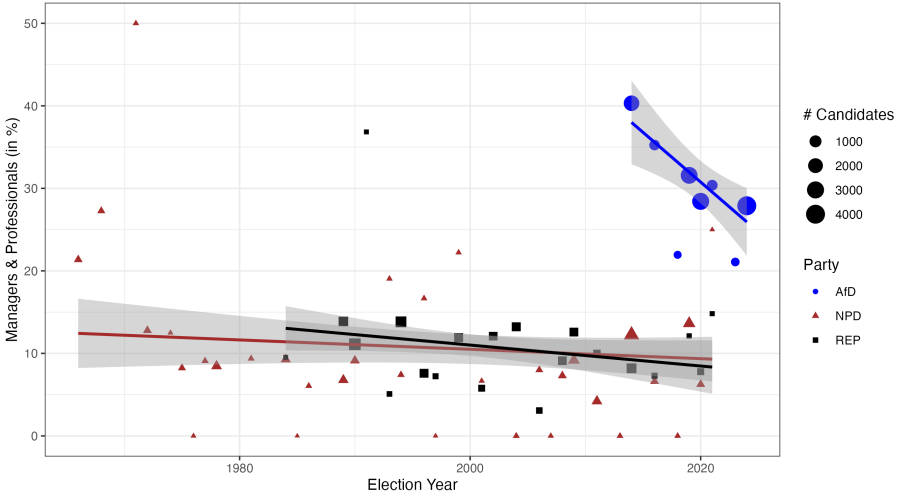
Consolidation, normalization, and candidate emergence

Drivers of adverse candidate emergence

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26.06.2025

Motivation



Research Question

RQ: What drives adverse candidate emergence in far-right parties?

Agenda

- ① Candidate emergence in stigmatized parties
- ② Drivers of adverse emergence
- ③ Context
- ④ Data
- ⑤ Results

Section 1

Candidate emergence in stigmatized parties

Theory

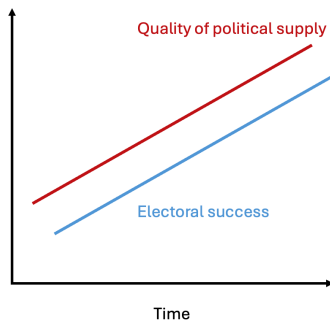
- **RQ: When can stigmatized parties recruit high quality candidates?**
- Norms-based theory (Valentim, 2024)
 - Links political supply to political demand
 - Three phase model
 - 1 Latency phase
 - 2 Activation phase
 - 3 Surfacing phase
- Three phase are
 - chronologically ordered
 - with each phase, higher electoral support & higher supply quality

Theory II

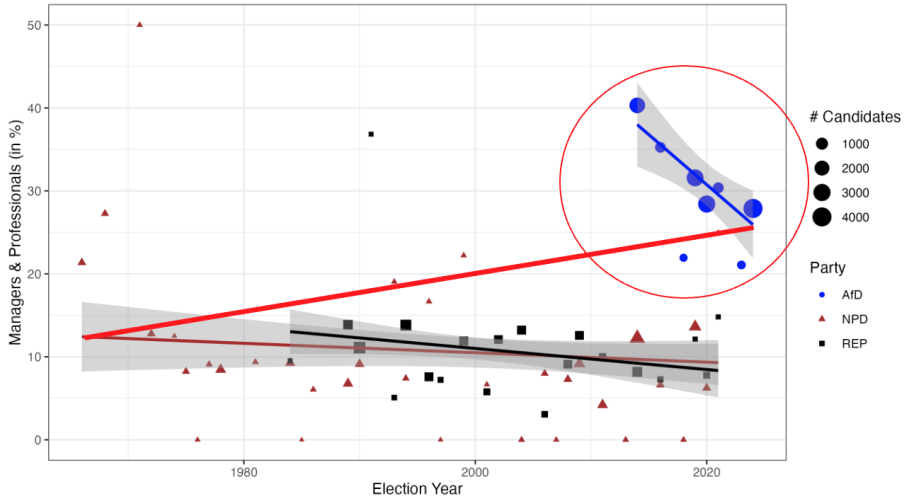
- Which drivers shift supply dynamically?

- ① Social norms
- ② Electoral success

- Social norms $\rightarrow$ electoral success $\rightarrow$ social norms



Theory III

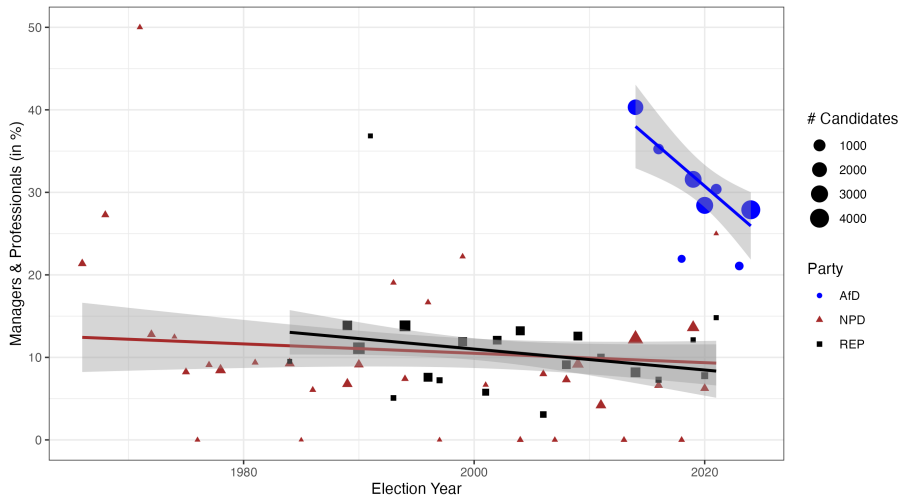


AfD vs. other parties | Green Party

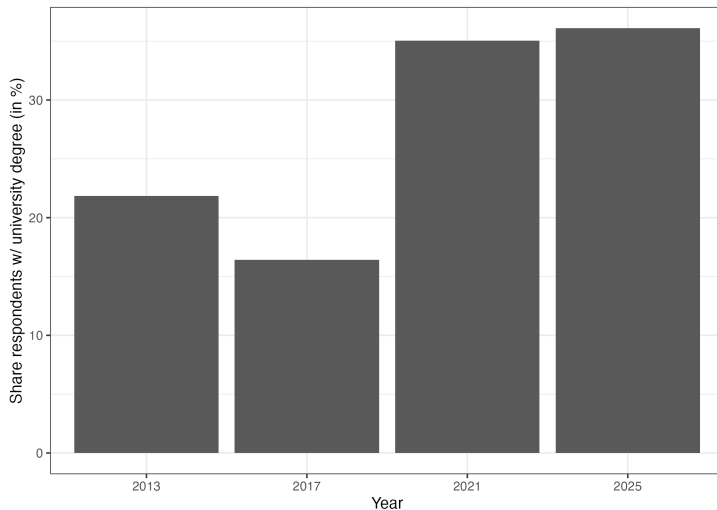
Drivers of adverse emergence

- Theory cannot explain activation phase trend for AfD
- Shortcomings
 - Norms affect voters not political elites
 - Emergence vs. selection
 - Appropriate level of analysis unclear
 - Case of AfD: Existing national-conservative elites
- Arguments
 - ① Higher sensitivity to changing norms of low- vs. high-skilled supporters
 - ② Higher exposure of high-skilled far-right party elite
 - ③ Rise of opportunistic actors

Alternative explanations I: Sticky elites



Alternative explanations II: Changing electorate



Section 2

Data & Context

Context

- AfD in Germany
 - Founded in 2013 as national-conservative party
 - Turn to nativism in following years (after 2015)
 - Increasing electoral success
- One of two genuinely new, successful parties in Germany after Greens in 1980s

Data

Electoral district	Political Party	Birthyear	Candidate name	Candidate address	Occupation	List position
Wahlkreis 001	Christlich Demokratische Union Deutschlands (CDU)	Geb. Jahr 1960	Med. technische Radiologieassistentin,	Dipl. Verwaltungswissenschaftler, Geb. Jahr 1959,	Kaufmännische Angestellte, Geb. Jahr 1963	07

Data II

- Data was recorded from all sources to minimize selection bias
 - Local newspaper (microfilm)
 - Official gazettes
 - Websites
- Extent of data
 - 14,000 local AfD candidates (county-level)
 - 300,000 other party candidates
- Skill Coding
 - Based on occupation
 - Semi-automatic coding of occupations (GPT & manual)
 - ISCO 1 or 2 coded as high-skilled (see also Art, 2011; Loxbo & Bolin 2016)

Local level | ISCO

Data III

- Interviews with party organizers
- In-depth interviews (about 90-120 minutes) with 7 local party organizers
 - 3 AfD organizers
 - 4 Green party organizers (in 1980s; focus of other chapters)
- Interviews covered
 - Personal experiences in the party
 - Development of local branches
 - Interactions with social environment

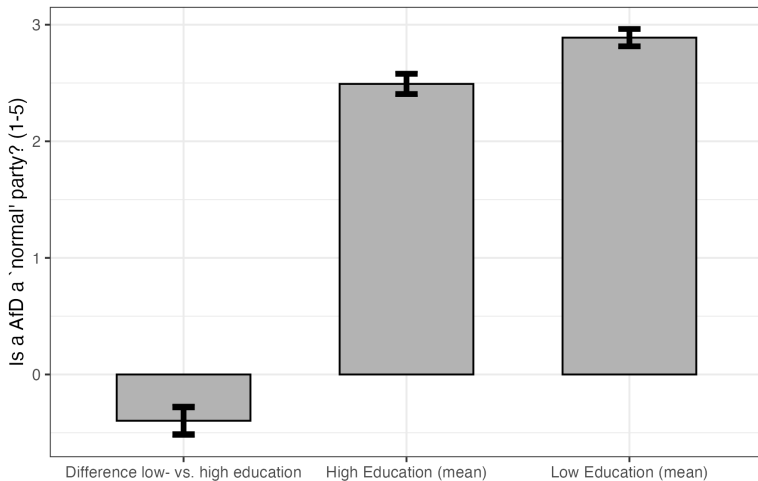
Section 3

Results

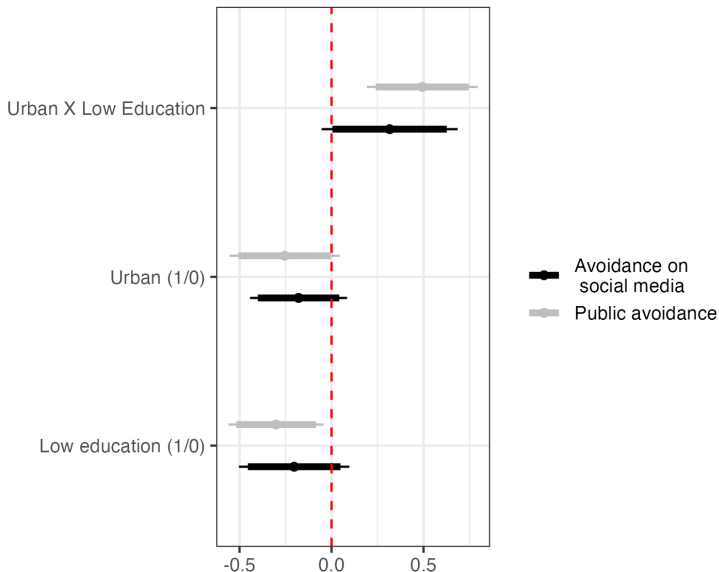
Differential Exposure/Sensitivity to Norms

- ① Argument: Low-skilled supporters exposed to less restrictive normative environment
 - Data:
 - original representative survey
 - Outcome:
 - Normalization of AfD
 - Is AfD a normal party?
- ② Argument: Low-skilled far-right supporters more attentive to external environment
 - Data:
 - Geo-coded survey in Saxony
 - Outcome:
 - Self-reported avoidance behavior
 - How often do you avoid talking publicly about your political opinion?

Differential Exposure to norms



Differential Sensitivity to norms



Differential exposure

- Argument: High-skilled far-right elites more exposed than low-skilled ones
- Data:
 - Coded information on AfD party elites
 - What kind of public information is available on elites?
 - Outcome:
 - Employer
 - Personal (address, telephone, email)
 - Online profiles (Linkedin/Xing)
 - Random sample of 100 low- vs. 100 high-skilled party elites
 - Handcoding

Why does information matter?

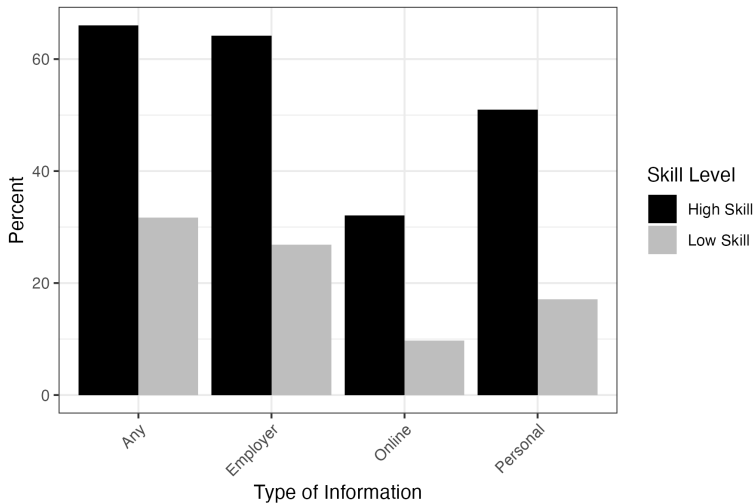
There was also a leak at [a] party congress. The [participant] data was leaked — including mine. People would show up at my door and cause trouble. I received phone calls like, “Hey [...], you have [...] beautiful daughters. If you want it to stay that way, leave the AfD.” And other things.

(Interviewee 3)

We had founded the local chapter and [...] made that public, [...] and three weeks later the spokesperson left the party because his boss told him, ‘If you’re active in that party, you’ll be the next to go.’ So that’s how it goes

(Interviewee 2)

Differential exposure



Opportunists

- Argument: Low-skilled opportunist actors saw change in making career in AfD
- Data:
 - Qualitative evidence from interviews
 - Describing
 - Motivation of other AfD elites
 - Opportunity structure for low-skilled supporters to pursue career

Opportunists

① Acknowledgement of opportunism in the AfD

“ut now, looking at the AfD overall — what has changed. Well, there’s always. . . I know, careful, Nazi comparison — but I always call them the “March casualties.” [Märzgefallene] Things are going well now, and suddenly people are coming — I handle a lot of admissions myself, and suddenly these people show up again.” (Interviewee 1)

Opportunists

② Description of opportunity structure

“What also had a negative impact was the so-called social membership fee. Back then, the AfD had — I’m not sure if it’s still the case — a yearly fee of 120 euros. There was a reduced rate of 60 euros for students, pupils, and retirees. In addition, they introduced a social membership fee of 30 euros. So anyone earning less than 14,400 euros a year, and who wasn’t a student or pupil, could become a member of the AfD for 30 euros. There were district associations where the majority of members were ‘30-euro specialists’—that was the internal nickname for these people. And this became noticeable across the entire party. It significantly lowered the overall level.” (Interviewee 3)

Opportunists

③ Opportunists in the AfD

*"Those are people who are really just in it for the money."
(Interviewee 1)*

*"There were people whose lives hadn't been particularly successful, and who then essentially discovered politics within the AfD as a business model. They saw the greatest opportunity to implement this model there. If you look at the AfD parliamentary group [in state], for probably 90% of them, this represents a career leap that wouldn't have been possible in their actual lives or real professions"
(Interviewee 2)*

Take-aways

- ① Continuous drop in skill level of local AfD party elites
- ② Norms may directly affect decision of politicians too
- ③ Low vs. high skilled elites differentially affected by
 - Exposure & sensitivity to norms environment
 - Public exposure
 - Outside options

Situated in a larger dissertation project

- Dissertation is about how new parties take root and the role elites play in these processes
 - Comparing 2 new parties in Germany (Greens in 1980s vs. AfD in 2010s)
 - Building on novel data of local party elites running ($N \sim 450,000$ for both periods)
- Focus on *causes* and *consequences* of elite traits in new parties
 - ① Electoral effects of local party elites
 - ② Organizational effects of local party elites
 - ③ **Drivers of local party elite emergence**

Thank you for your attention!

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Section 4

Appendix

Comparison with other parties

Comparison with Green Party development

County-level focus

- County-level is situated inbetween local and higher-level (federal/state) politics
- Many (almost all) careers jumpstarted at this level
- Important candidate selection level
- Top-level organization for all municipal organizations
 - organizational control
 - organizational finances
 - organizational power

Motivation Local Politics

"I've always said, a young party has to put down roots in local politics. It needs local faces. [...] And so you have to get the grassroots anchored."

"It was always difficult to find active people [...] We have had business owners. But you don't run a local party association like a company."

"There are functioning local associations and some just don't work. But it all depends on the people [on the ground]."

All quotes from interviewed local AfD organizers.

ISCO coding

- ISCO-08 classification as basis for coding (see also Art 2011; Loxbo & Bolin 2016)
- 10 categories
 - I coded categories 1 and 2 as high skill
 - These categories include occupations for which one usually needs university education
 - Examples: Medical doctors, managers, software engineers

Norms environment in dating markets

